The kings of these three dynasties are among those celebrated in the earliest literature of the Tamil South, collectively known as Sangam (also written Cankam), taking its name from three assemblies of scholars and poets who between them are said to have created a great corpus of poetic literature, of which very little survives. The most detailed account of these Sangams was set down by a literary commentary written in about the eighth century by a poet of Madurai named Nakkirar. By his reckoning, the first Sangam took place at Then Madurai, or 'South Madurai', under the patronage of a Pandya king named Ma Kirti, with the sage Agastya acting as the convenor. It lasted for 4440 years, involved 4449 poets, including gods and sages, and it produced Agastya's lost grammar *Agathiyam*. The second Sangam was held at a place called Kapatapuram, lasted 3700 years, had Agastya's disciple Tholkappiyar as convenor and produced his *Tolkappiyam*.

These first two assemblies were held in cities located to the south of Kanyakumari in the country of Kumarikkantam or Kumarinadu. Here, it seems, was the cradle of ancient Tamil civilisation, South India's Atlantis, occupying a continental shelf that was lost to the sea in one or more catastrophic inundations. The third Sangam was held in Uttara Madurai, or 'North Madurai', so in the present city of Madurai. It lasted a mere 1850 years and involved 449 poets, its first chairman being a survivor of the inundation.

A lot has been said in recent years about this supposed lost continent of Kumarikkantam, which in some quarters also goes by the name Ilemuriakkantam, 'the country of Ilimuria'. This last is no more than a Tamilisation of the word Lemuria, coined by a British zoologist named Philip Sclater in 1864.[11] Sclater's researches into fossils had led him to conclude (wrongly) that the engaging long-tailed, bug-eyed primates known as lemurs found on the island of Madagascar had once had ancestral cousins in India. This